

10-11 Performance Review

Manager Review

Jonathan Daniel Micklos

Performance Review: 04/01/2010 - 03/31/2011

Reviewer: Eric Bottom

Role: Manager

Status: Completed

Manager: Eric Bottom

Overall Performance Summary

Employee Summary:

This past year, much has happened with myself and the Buying Experience Team. For 2010 I had some goals that were derived from my 2009 review. For purposes of proper documentation, I would like to point out that I still believe that my 2009 review was written with little consideration for the context of what was going on at the time and was grossly inaccurate. The places that were listed as areas in need of improvement and the reason for why my performance was graded as it was include:

- Time Management / Project Prioritization: In my last review, I was said to have had problems choosing the right priority projects to work on and that I was taking on too much at once.
- Code Quality: In my last review, there were a couple instances that were pointed out where small user experience bugs had gotten out into production. This had only happened for a very short period of time.

To my knowledge, both of the above issues were non-issues for at least 4 months coming up to my 2009 review. Additionally, both issues had never been brought to my attention (despite my repeated requests for feedback and career guidance) until the summer of 2009. It is quite inappropriate to expect performance at or exceeding a specific level if that level is never communicated despite repeat requests for feedback on performance. I had been told by Devraj Varadhan (my then manager's manager and my previous manager the year prior) that these issues would only be short-term problems to deal with. I was told that I needed to trust in this. As a direct result, I stayed with the team and worked very hard. My review could not have been further from what I was told would be the case.

The manner in which these issues were handled was (and remains) unfathomably shocking to me. It has caused me to lose a great deal of trust in many of those who I work with. I find this to be incredibly important to mention as I find trust to be absolutely paramount for a healthy and productive working environment. I have sought out multiple avenues to fix what I feel to be wrong with my past review, but to no avail. To my knowledge, neither of the two issues has been brought up a single time (even as I ask my peers for feedback throughout the year) as issues during 2010. And with that, I recognize that even though this past review process has significantly impacted my relationship with and trust in Amazon, I recognize I must humbly concede on this topic if I wish to move forward. I ultimately remain encouraged by the words of my current management chain and the organizational changes going on around me. I want to be at Amazon, I greatly enjoy my work and I know that I am a valuable individual contributor here at Amazon. This review period, I wish to put my concerns surrounding my 2009 review to bed and bring them up no more.

In this review, I will show how not only are the areas of improvement that were listed for my 2009 review are now completely and fully non-issues (and have been for quite some time) but that I have also grown considerably and am performing at the level of an SDE-II.

The things that I have worked on this year that I would like to review can be easily broken down into three categories:

1. Projects
2. Operations Tasks
3. Mentoring, Consultation and Education

For projects in this past year, I have worked on:

- The Enhanced Variations Drop Down Project: This project was part of the larger overall baby diapers revamp project. This section of the revamp involved, replacing the traditional Twister Variations Matrix with content rich drop downs dubbed "DonsBoxes." These DonsBoxes would be used to not only show variational dimension information, but also availability, pricing, Prime, Subscribe and Save, and price per unit information for quick comparison shopping within the dropdowns themselves. The EVDD project had two parts:

1. The Twister Cleanup Project
2. EVDD in US Baby Diapers

While Corinne Russell worked to remove unused Twister JavaScript and Mason Code, I worked to decouple the user interface of Twister from the underlying code that manages variational state. The results of our efforts was not only a significantly smaller JavaScript footprint for Twister (~10kb less), but a Twister where new user interfaces could be written to replace the Twister Variations Matrix on a detail page without having to re write any variational state management JavaScript or Mason. This was no small change; it required a month of work from both Corinne and myself (two months total). The change required substantial testing on the part of QA and was finally released into production without any major problems or any degradation in performance. Once that work was complete, I could begin work on the creation of the DonsBox Div/CSS/JS based drop down library and the Enhanced Variations Drop Down flavor of Twister. Although originally implemented for baby diapers in grocery, baby and HPC, I made sure to implement the DonsBox and EVDD so that it could be immediately used on the product lines. These added requirements included adding MAP functionality, EMWA handling and Image Swatches (neither of which is used in baby diapers). Additionally, I not only thoroughly tested the EVDD twister flavor on baby diapers, but also on a number of other categories, including Shoes, Kitchen and Apparel. The development time for the implementation of the EVDD took around a month to finish. During this time, I presented prototypes of the EVDD to others involved in the project. Additionally, I was responsible for managing and sticking to the schedule for the EVDD. Once complete, the user experience launched with no major defects or bugs. This change resulted in the following:

- Retail Baby Diaper GMS +5.02%
- Diaper Retail Conversion +3.68%
- Diaper Retail Units +4.88%
- 13 Days Pre-Weblab: \$3,033,363
- 13 Days at Weblab 100%: \$3,569,739
- 13 Day Difference Before and After Weblab: \$536,376

Please note that baby diapers was already Twisterized under the traditional swatch flavor for Twister. Because of this, we were able to see if the EVDD flavor introduced any negative performance impact. It did not.

- Twisterization of US Software: Once we were done with EVDD in Baby Diapers, we wanted to find out what the performance impact of Twisterizing a category in general could be with today's current Twister. We chose to Twisterize US Software as it had already been Twisterized once in the past. However, after the original Twisterization, the weblab had to be turned down due to performance issues and a decrease in sales. This time around, I Twisterized US Software under the EVDD Twister Flavor. Additionally, now we had a running EVDD test case that utilized MAP. We were able to launch EVDD in US Software with no functional bugs. However, because of the impact of Twister to the latency performance of the category, we had to turn the weblab down.

- Twister for Books in CA - I implemented the changes necessary for launching Twister for Books in

Canada. Apart from the normal binding map work necessary to launch Twister for Books in a locale, T4B in Canada needed to support the display of new currency types in the Media Matrix and multiple languages. I did the work to launch this in March of 2010. Additionally, I implemented a debugging framework and user interface for Twister for Books in order to not only track down sources of issues on books detail pages, but also to see whether or not a given environment has the requisite configuration and software stack to display the T4B matrix properly. Twister for Books in CA launched without any major issues and achieved the following metrics:

- Books Overall: GMS (+0.28%) (not statistically significant), Units (+0.03%) (not statistically significant) and Conversion (+0.01%) (not statistically significant)
- Books Retail: GMS (-0.21%) (not statistically significant), Conversion (+0.06%) (not statistically significant) and Units (+0.03%) (not statistically significant)
- Books 3P: GMS (+1.03%) (statistically significant), Conversion (+0.15%) (not statistically significant), and Units (-0.03%) (not statistically significant)
- Distilled Buy-Box: Towards the end of the end of the year, our team was tasked with improving latency on the detail page. The first major Buy-Box related project that we worked on was the Distilled Buy-Box. The objective of the DBB was to turn all of the separate components of the Buy-Box into discrete features. This way, it is much easier to deduce the performance impact of various parts of the Buy-Box. Additionally, it become quite straight forward on how to add and remove things to/from it as well. Overall, this project was simply good engineering. I developed two main parts of this project. On one part, I created new features to replace various parts of the Buy-Box and created a command line tool for generating cookies with active Amazon sessions for various types of users (not-logged in, logged in, logged in prime, logged in PayPhrase, etc.). The session cookies that the tool would generate could them be used for Buy-Box scraping/testing tools in order to test various types of users.
- VMDC Deprecation: The VMDC was responsible for storing the various language specific visual representations of variational dimensions. As an example, it would store the mapping of 'size_name' to "Size" in US English. However, since we made the transition to storing this information in translator, we were able to begin deprecating the VMDC. I made sure to verify that no traffic was hitting the VMDC before pulling the plug. I had noticed that despite removing the Twister Mason code which calls the VMDC that it was still receiving traffic. Unbeknownst to our team, others had started using it. I worked with those team and individuals (along with the help of the PA team) to get them all moved over to the new translator based solution. Once traffic went down to nothing, I was able to finally pull the plug.
- Holiday Availability Messaging: During this year, I worked on HAM twice. One time I implemented new Holiday Availability Messaging on the OLP. The second project involved implementing change to get the 2010-2011 holiday season HAM messaging working on the detail page. These projects involved working with other teams that our team does not regularly interface with. When launched, HAM launched for the 2010-2011 season without issue.

Operations task I have worked on in the last year include:

- Scaling: In 2010, as in 2009, I worked on determining host capacity requirements for CARS and made requests for them. I worked on this with Brady Montz.
- FATALs: Within the way in which Twister handled AJAX requests, there was a mechanism that would trigger a FATAL in the event that no Parent ASIN was identified in the AJAX request. As a result, every so often, our on-call would have to respond to SEV-2's caused by FATAL spikes caused by users playing around with the arguments in our AJAX request URLs. In order to prevent this from happening in the future, I modified the logical check for the Parent ASIN so that it would verify that the referring domain was Amazon before triggering a FATAL. With this modification launched, instances of this type of FATAL have ceased.
- Twister Defense: Until this year, there were no limitations on the size of variational families. The lack of these restrictions has allowed the creation of large variational sets. These large sets generally result in very slow detail pages. These pages have had a history of being the means to cause website availability issues when hit frequently enough. While Allen Chen had already implemented a hard limit on the number of visual buckets that CARS would be willing to process (prevent a DoS opportunity in our image rank code), we still needed a hard limit on the size of variational sets. I implemented an initial hard limit of 2500 variational children to a set. If breached,

any variational set with more than 2500 children would result in a 404 when its detail page is hit.

- Debugging Tools: This year I continued my work on the internal BX-owned debugging tools. I made 10 independent submissions to the BXInternalMason package. These changes included:

- Store Model Checker: Quite frequently, the question comes up: "Do you know if this store is a default child of default parent model store?" Since this happens so frequently, I wrote a tool that queries AWOBS to ascertain just that. Given a list of product group IDs, this tool will output the store model for each.

- EMWA Debugging: Since CARS acts as an EMWA information cache for variational sets, I added a section to the variational debugger that compares what CARS thinks about the EMWA status of a variational family's children and what the actual status is for each child.

- Child Count and Availability Information: In combination with the work I did to prevent rendering the detail pages of large variational families, I added a section to the variational debugger which lists the number of children in a given variational set. I added another section that lists the children currently available.

- Twister for Books Service Dependency Check: As mentioned as part of Twister for Books CA, I added a section to the BXInternalMason package which lets the user know whether or not the Retail Website instance that the package is running on has the necessary configuration and software stack to display the T4B matrix properly.

- Variation Dimension String ID: Another often asked question is: "What are the string IDs for the variational dimensions for a given ASIN?" I added a debugging section that adds this.

- New Debugging Framework: As part of the greater ASIN Purgenator Project, I wrote a Perl Library for writing debuggers. The tenants of this library not only include ways of implementing test cases for a given debugger and data input, but also writing various suggested routes to take for given states. As an example, if a variational family is missing a variation theme, the debugger may be written to suggest writing a TT to TAM. Various types of suggestion objects were written. These included ones for creating Trouble Tickets, creating Contacts Uses, Going to a Wiki, sending an Email and going to a specific URL. The entire debugger framework was written from the ground up on test driven design. Once complete, I documented the framework and handed it off to Ravi on the Twister Team.

- CARS Tasks: As was the case with last year, I worked on various CARS operations tasks in 2010. One example includes triaging and handing off the work required to deprecate CARS' Relationship and Item update TPEDs and reconfigure the associated AMP Queues. I worked with the IOP team and Twister Team to come up with a proper implementation and test plan for the migration. Other operational tasks have included things such as updating the visual dimension configurations in CARS.

- DonsBox Consultation: The DonsBox is not only being used in the EVDD. The DonsBox library is now being used in the Immersive View as well. Additionally, the DonsBox is now being considered for use in the Subscribe and Save "Manage Your Subscriptions" page. With this work, I have consulted both teams on using the DonsBox library.

- i-Device Behavior: The introduction of the iPad in this past year has brought various mobile-webkit behavioral quirks to light. One such quirk was a bug in calculating offset in JavaScript. As a result, most popovers on i-Devices (until recently) were placed in an incorrect position when the given page was zoomed in on. Additionally, mobile-webkit handles onClick and onHover JavaScript events in a very strange way. When a user touches the screen, the iPad triggers an onTouchStart event. If onTouchStart and onTouchEnd events are not registered, mobile-webkit will look to onClick and onHover. The first touch results in a call to onHover and the second results in a call to onClick. As a direct result, HTML elements with onHover and onClick events require two touches to trigger an onClick event. I specifically worked on solving these two problems for the DonsBox on the i-Devices. Once this was fixed, I worked with Ken Day towards the implementation of an RCX wide fix for the offset bug. This fix is currently available and implemented in the Amazon Popover Library.

Mentoring, Consultation and Education:

- Matthew Precious and Marcus Gartner: Both Matthew and Marcus interned at Amazon this past year. While I was neither Marcus' nor Matthew's direct mentor, I did participate in mentoring them.

- The Twister Team: This year I spent a good amount of time Mentoring various members of the the BX India Team. As mentioned earlier, I have spent time mentoring the BX India Team on dealing

with various aspects of CARS (including the IOP migration mentioned earlier and general administration and problem diagnosis steps) and Twister (including the DonsBox in Immersive View work).

- Giles Burgess: Giles is new to Amazon this year. As Giles got accustomed to working at Amazon, and was initially finding his way around the Twister for Books code base (both front end and CARS) and the Variational Twister code base, I was there to help guide him with any of the questions he had.

- Jen Walsh: I worked closely with Jen Walsh this year. Not only did I work with her on a number of projects such as the EVDD in US Software project, but I also spent a considerable amount of time working with her on various Twister Issues. This is Jen's first year at Amazon. She is now the Product Manager for the Twister Team. This is by no means an accident. She has worked incredibly hard to understand Twister from front to back, the various performance and UX pitfalls and ways to solve these issues. I have spent significant time working with Jen to help her understand Twister, the data model it uses, ways to improve Twister and all of the minutia that is a part of it.

With the work I have done this year, I have shown that the problems outlined in my last review are no longer issues.

- Time Management / Project Prioritization: Projects have consistently come in on time.

- Code Quality: There have been zero major bugs that I have released into production this year. Additionally, I have actively worked cross company to reduce bugs in others code. A great example of this is the work that I have done with Ken Day to fix i-device website behavior issues.

Manager Summary:

As Jon notes he received an unfavorable performance review in 2009, while working within the Twister team for previous managers. Jon has relayed his concerns about that review to me; I've also had discussions with one of the former managers prior to managing Jon directly. While I can't speak to all of the specifics since I wasn't there I do agree, based on what's documented in that review, that these areas were identified as needing improvement in 2010:

- 1) time management / project prioritization
- 2) code quality

Jon worked to address these issues during 2010 even though he largely believed they were inaccurate representations of his performance. During 2010 Jon repeatedly expressed concern about how his past performance was judged and the circumstances surrounding him and his team. He admitted distrust for both his former and current management chain, based on past events. As such he struggled at times; his strong belief about an inaccurate 2009 review coupled with his assertion that he was already operating at an SDE II level impacted his ability to consistently focus on and deliver on team goals. That's not to say he didn't do strong work at times; he did as evidenced by the projects he's highlighted in his self review. When Jon believes in what he's doing his output is generally strong and consistent. But when he doesn't believe he showed instances of inconsistent focus and productivity as well as displays of anger/frustration within the team environment. In Amazon parlance this type of behavior is counter to the "disagree and commit" leadership principle, specifically the "once a decision is determined, they commit wholly" portion of that principle.

By early 2011 Jon was placed on a performance improvement plan, which he successfully completed at the end of March. It's now up to Jon to decide if he wants to continue the type of focus, commitment and proper behavior that helped him come through that performance improvement plan successfully. I'll add additional comments about this in the Strengths/Areas for Improvement sections.

Jon worked on a variety of projects and operational tasks over the last year, including:

- 1) Enhanced Variations Drop Down Project: Jon's work here was in direct support of one of his 2010

goals ("Support, Improve and Optimize the DonsBox and EVDD").

He partnered with another developer (Corinne Russell) on phase one to clean up the Twister code. Corinne handled removal of unnecessary JavaScript code/restructuring of remaining code; Jon worked to reduce the tight coupling of the Twister UI from the underlying variational state functionality. As he notes this phase of the project both reduced the JS latency impact as well as providing greater flexibility for adding additional Twister user experience elements.

From there Jon handled phase two (implementing a new variations dropdown UI for US Diapers) almost completely on his own. This was one of Jon's brightest stretches of 2010 and I know he/the Twister business team was pleased with the resulting UI and very positive web lab metrics. Defect count relative to the code Jon wrote was also very low.

Some relevant peer feedback:

"One of Jon's huge projects this year was the enhanced dropdown treatment. For that project, I only did a little bit of early research and documentation. From there, it was all Jon from start to finish. He worked very closely with design, product management, and QA to launch this project. I thought the end result was quite good and was a nice improvement over the previous diapers experience. While I didn't get much of an opportunity to look over his code, I found it impressive that Jon was able to do the whole thing on his own, especially since it was his first major JS project."

2) Twister extensions: given Jon extensive background in the Twister space he made strong contributions to the US Software and CA Books Twister extensions. He also provided guidance to other team members (specifically Matt Precious and Giles Burgess) on their work in the US Music and DE/UK Books Twister extensions. As he notes we were unable to formally launch US Software due to latency impact. And he handled nearly all of the related software development for the CA Books Twister launch, even going the extra mile to create the debugger framework he mentions. This is a good example of Jon's ability to go above and beyond, based on his dedication to and belief in extending and improving the Twister user experience. He knows the Twister space well, believes in the user experience and sees the value in improving it. I'd encourage him to apply this type of attitude to all the work he does.

3) VDMC migration: Jon took the lead on this deprecation, leveraging his strong knowledge of Twister. As he notes the deprecation effort took an unexpected turn once Jon discovered other Amazon clients were using the system we otherwise thought was used for Twister only. Jon worked closely with these teams and SDK to move them to the translator alternative. Jon's work here was thorough. Again, his attitude towards this work was positive even though it certainly wasn't the most glamorous or customer facing. This is another example of Jon applying himself when he believes in a project/the outcome.

4) Holiday availability messaging: this was a trying project for Jon since we were basically acting as an outsourced development resource for this NPI project. As such he was frequently called upon by the project manager to debug issues where root cause wasn't due to anything he/we had directly done (or had direct control over). He managed to keep his patience throughout many requests to "debug this devo issue." His calm demeanor and effective communication about root causes (once he discovered them) showed the strong commitment, focus on problem solving and proper demeanor Jon's capable of.

4) Operational projects: one of Jon's 2010 goals was to minimize the time he spent on operations (specifically CARS related issues). While he did spend some time working directly in the CARS space (e.g. determining CARS hardware scaling needs, addition of EMWA debugging functionality) he focused most of his efforts on enabling others -- specifically our new Seattle based SDE's and our Bangalore based Twister development resources -- to take over CARS maintenance tasks. As he notes he educated our Bangalore team on the work required to deprecate CARS TPED's and reconfigure the AMP queues. He then acted as a consultant, answering questions as needed while the Bangalore team carried out the actual work. And he educated newer Seattle team members

(intern Matthew Precious, new SDE Giles Burgess) on overall architecture and debugging/bug fixing as various issues arose. This was a good area of growth for Jon -- using his expertise to teach others and extend the network of people who can support CARS -- and I'd encourage him to keep this up. This approach not only helps his team members grow but also removes the burden associated with being one of the only resident experts on CARS. That frees him up to work on other things.

As he notes Jon contributed in several other operational areas. Of particular note was his work around diagnosing/fixing Twister related Fatais as well as extending defensive coding against overly large Twister variation sets. Over the course of the year Twister related Fatais and unconstrained variation sets increasingly impacted both the Twister customer experience as well as our client side latency. His modifications to the logical variational parent check helped dramatically reduce that entire class of fatais. He also took it upon himself to work closely with the Twister product manager (Jen Walsh) to educate her on how she could find and kill large, unconstrained variation sets. Those efforts helped reign in an otherwise recurrent and costly CX and latency impact. And Jon also extended the Mason "Twister defense" to limit variation set size to a max of 2500 children. While not the most elegant solution (we knew that going in) we desperately needed some stopgap solution -- and Jon quickly stepped up to that task. Again, this is a good example of Jon's ability to go above and beyond, based on his dedication to and belief in extending and improving the Twister user experience. He's in his comfort zone there; I'd encourage him to apply the same attitude and work ethic when he has to work *outside* his comfort zone. He's shown the ability to do this; the next step is consistency.

Some relevant peer feedback:

"Jon has also taken the initiative to improve a lot of our internal operational tools. He did a great job setting up all the BX internal tools. They have been very helpful in improving our ability to debug issues. It also is a great place to point external people so they can help self-diagnose their issues. This has definitely saved us a bunch of time."

5) i device behavior improvements: we had numerous customer experience issues with our websites on the I pad/i devices in general. We partnered with our Bangalore team to fix a vareity of bugs affecting detail pages. Some of the thornier bugs was related to how i devices dealt with our JavaScript related to popovers and on click/on hover events. We ultimately needed fixes to be added to our popover library; that solution wasn't to be available in an acceptable timeline. So Jon dug in and devised a short term fix (e.g. suppression of the popovers) and then engaged the JSET team re: the larger, fuller solution. As he notes that solution is now in place. Jon showed strong ownership, ingenuity and commitment to both implementing a stop gap solution and raising awareness with the JSET team on the fuller solution. His bias for action and passion for the right solutions was excellent; again, I'd encourage him to consistently demonstrate those competencies throughout his suite of projects and tasks.

6) Mentoring, consultation and education: as mentioned previously Jon provided mentoring to the Seattle and Bangalore teams (CARS related work, Twister functionality) and Twister product management (educating Jen Walsh on detection/removal of large variation sets). He also provided informal mentorship to our two interns (Matt Precious and Marcus Gartner). He was especially helpful with two new hires - Giles Burgess (a new SDE on the team) and Jen Walsh (in her first year as Twister product manager). He provided early guidance for Giles and Matt as they were ramping up on their Twister projects, giving them background on CARS, the general Twister architecture as well as answering specific question related to implementation. And Jon helped accelerate Jen's very steep learning curve related to Twister, educating her on the Twister architecture, working closely with her on the enhanced variations dropdown and partnering on Twister fatais reduction/elimination of larger variations sets. These were all areas where Jon was an expert, felt comfortable and believed in maintaining a high customer experience bar. This is the type of commiment Jon should show for all his work.

Jon also had two other goals for the year: "complete more SDE II level projects" and "work cross team and take on minor TPM roles in the team." One of the SDE II level projects we'd earmarked for him was migrating CARS to SABLE. However after researching this (with some assistance from Giles Burgess) the cost to move to SABLE was prohibitive. So that project was cancelled. The Bangalore based Twister team will now migrate CARS to a still-to-be-determined alternative in 2012.

Jon's work on the enhanced variation dropdown (as discussed previously) also fell into an SDE II-level type project. Jon also participated in the implementation of the distilled buy box (splitting the existing monolithic buybox into separate features, to enable more accurate latency measurement, proper ownership of externally-owned buying functions and more modular development). He partnered with Corinne Russell, Allen Chen, Giles Burgess and Amit Saurav on the design and implementation. As he notes one particular area of focus was developing a testing methodology to verify the buybox functionality integrity after it was split into separate features. His contributions here were strong and it's these type of complex problems that offer Jon SDE II level type opportunities.

His work on the distilled buybox contributed to progress towards his final goal, "work cross team and take on minor TPM roles in the team." As he notes he didn't get many TPM type opportunities; he did work without any real TPM assistance on his enhanced dropdown project. And he's done an extensive deep dive on a still-to-be-scheduled NPI project, Bundles. Given many of the technical hurdles for Bundles revolve around how to treat/present variations Jon was well suited for the technical scoping he/Christoph Bichsel (one of our BX TPMs) have done so far. Provided Bundles does get fully resourced (our team is not currently staffed to cover all the development and product manager aspects of this large NPI project) this would be an excellent opportunity for Jon to showcase SDE II level skills. We're currently working with the CE and Pricing teams to confirm their funding of the necessary resources; pending approval of that we'd likely engage Jon as the BX Apps resource on the project.

Identify Strengths

Employee Summary:

[Leadership Principle] Customer Obsession

[Description] Leaders start with the customer and work backwards. They work vigorously to earn and keep customer trust. Although leaders pay attention to competitors, they obsess over customers. Our customers are the number one thing which drives me to produce. I believe that there are many examples throughout this past year where I can point to this being seen in my work. Examples include:

- The thorough testing of and implementation for not only use cases specifically found in baby diapers for the EVDD, but those found in Twister in general
- Suggesting, adding to our sprint, designing and implementing a full Perl Debugger Framework (used for the ASIN Purgenator Project)
- Forwarding on different new user experiences which I find across the web as suggestions for changes at Amazon
- The work I have done with Jen Walsh to figure out how to make a more performant twister with a better user experience
- The proactive work I have done to resolve i-device bugs across the website

[Leadership Principle] Ownership

[Description] Leaders are owners. They think long term and don't sacrifice long-term value for short-term results. They act on behalf of the entire company, beyond just their own team. They never say "that's not my job".

When faced with a great problem, or challenge concerning something I own, I am rarely deterred. A great example of this is the fact that I stayed up coding overnight on more than one occasion for the

Perl Debugger Framework (and went to work when the sun rose). When my development of the framework was complete, I made sure that the framework was properly documented and handed off to Ravi of the BX Twister Team for the ASIN Purgenator project.

[Leadership Principle] Invent and Simplify

[Description] Leaders expect and require innovation and invention from their teams and always find ways to simplify. They are externally aware, look for new ideas from everywhere, and are not limited by “not invented here”. As we do new things, we accept that we may be misunderstood for long periods of time.

In line with customer obsession and ownership, I often invent and simplify. Good examples of this include:

- I implemented the DonsBox for the EVDD as a standalone library which could be easily reused as a traditional drop down replacement in various places on Amazon.com.

[Leadership Principle] Are Right, A Lot

[Description] Leaders are right a lot. They have strong business judgment and good instincts.

I believe that I have demonstrated great business instinct and judgement. A good example of this would be the current work I am doing on the Product Bundles design.

[Leadership Principle] Earn Trust of Others

[Description] Leaders are sincerely open-minded, genuinely listen, and are willing to examine their strongest convictions with humility.

Over the last year I have closely worked with and gained the trust of Jen Walsh. Together we have worked on optimizing and improving Twister.

[Leadership Principle] Have Backbone; Disagree and Commit

[Description] Leaders are obligated to respectfully challenge decisions when they disagree, even when doing so is uncomfortable or exhausting. Leaders have conviction and are tenacious. They do not compromise for the sake of social cohesion. Once a decision is determined, they commit wholly.

I have backbone and am more than willing to take a stand and commit on various topics. In fact, this may be so much so almost to my detriment. A great example of this is the various points that I disagreed and committed with the work being done during our performance related work in the later part of 2010.

[Leadership Principle] Deliver Results

[Description] Leaders focus on the key inputs for their business and deliver them with the right quality and in a timely fashion. Despite setbacks, they rise to the occasion and never settle.

A great example of this would be the delivery of the DonsBox and Enhanced Variations Drop Down.

[Leadership Principle] Insist on the Highest Standards

[Description] Leaders have relentlessly high standards - many people may think these standards are unreasonably high. Leaders are continually raising the bar and drive their teams to deliver high quality products, services and processes. Leaders ensure that defects do not get sent down the line and that problems are fixed so they stay fixed.

This is something which can be said as a strength for our entire team. Our bar for code quality requirements in code reviews has risen significantly over the last few years. Additionally, once again, the Enhanced Variations Drop Down is a great example of how I demand the highest standards. I implemented well past the required use cases for EVDD in Baby Diapers and tested my work more than thoroughly. EVDD in Baby Diapers was launched without any major bugs. Additionally, I would consider myself an extremely thorough code reviewer with a keen eye for detail and proper software engineering.

[Leadership Principle] Think Big

[Description] Thinking small is a self-fulfilling prophecy. Leaders create and communicate a bold

direction that inspires results. They think differently and look around corners for ways to serve customers.

At Amazon, I find it very hard not to think big. Thinking big (for me) goes hand and hand with customer obsession. As an example of how I do this, I have already began documenting the various ways required code changes to code bases such as Twister will have direct positive impact to various other projects. As an example, Product Bundles will need to have multiple versions of Twister running on the same Detail Page. This code change will greatly impact the performance of Quick View. Another example is that for the variational model to work properly for Product Bundles, we will need to be able to easily add multiple ASINs to cart and checkout at once. The addition of this functionality will have direct positive impact on the accessories initiative as it will be possible to add multiple ASINs (accessories) to the cart and checkout pipeline at once.

[Leadership Principle] Bias for Action

[Description] Speed matters in business. Many decisions and actions are reversible and do not need extensive study. We value calculated risk taking.

While we have not had a discrete list of tasks to perform for Product Bundles as of yet, I have been pushing hard to figure out what exactly needs to be done, and do it. I have been doing this work with the work that I have otherwise had on the Sprint. Now that the tasks which need to be done for Product Bundles is a bit more succinct, we have been able to begin adding tasks to our sprint.

Manager Summary:

Jon lists several SDE/leadership principles as strengths. I agree with some but not all of these; some of these areas do need improvement, especially when it comes to consistently displaying these principles. He's definitely shown improvement in recent months (e.g. late 2011 and during 2012) after a performance improvement plan that ran from mid February until the end of March.

I agree with Jon's assessment of his strengths with respect to Customer Obsession, Ownership, Deliver Results, Insist on High Standards and Bias for Action -- when he's fully committed to a particular project or type of work. He's shown high levels of all of these principles in spaces he believes in and is familiar with - Twister in general (both CX and latency related issues), the enhanced variations dropdown project, Bundles research, addressing i device bugs.

Some relevant peer feedback:

"Jon has a lot of energy and when this energy is focused on a specific task, he is a great partner who has a very clear sense of customer need. He has shown clear ability to change direction and is able to adjust his plan to better align with business need. Jon definitely has a bias for action and when given clear timelines, he has proven to always over delivered. Once given direction, Jon is able to take a concept and run with it. Jon's energy is a very positive thing in most circumstances and once he begins harness it in a more effective manner, he has obvious leadership potential."

Jon's most effective when he's focused on a manageable number of tasks. He's made recent strides in limiting the number of commitments he signs up for (especially those that aren't related to sprint tasks) and protecting his time to ensure completion of those.

Some peer feedback:

"Jon has done a much better job lately in estimating tasks and delivering them. I suggest continuing to limit multi-tasking. Getting a set of things reliably done is more important than taking on too many projects. Jon's willingness to help out plays a role here. I certainly don't want to discourage this but I suggest that he keeps an eye on it."

Jon's demonstrated he can Insist on the Highest Standards, as evidenced by one of the key contributions he made to the distilled buy box redesign project.

Some relevant peer feedback:

"When working on the buy box redesign, he has been very focused on making sure we cover all possible test cases (different user states, twister, etc.). This kind of thinking is very helpful, and it allows our team to make sure our focus is not too narrow."

Jon's made key contributions this year, as the list of projects he notes shows. The key for him going forward is consistency, in both focus and maintaining a positive outlook, even in situations of high pressure or when he doesn't agree with an opinion or outcome.

Identify Areas for Improvement

Employee Summary:

[Leadership Principle] Have Backbone; Disagree and Commit

[Description] Leaders are obligated to respectfully challenge decisions when they disagree, even when doing so is uncomfortable or exhausting. Leaders have conviction and are tenacious. They do not compromise for the sake of social cohesion. Once a decision is determined, they commit wholly.

I am extremely willing to disagree and commit when I feel that something is wrong or does not make sense. While I have this listed as a strength, I will also list it as an area for improvement as I believe that I may be too will to disagree and commit at times. In short, I need to be better at picking my battles.

[Leadership Principle] Earn Trust of Others

[Description] Leaders are sincerely open-minded, genuinely listen, and are willing to examine their strongest convictions with humility.

While it is that I have earned the trust of Jen Walsh, I need to work on better earning the trust of my management chain. I do not always properly communicate the extra work I am doing (despite otherwise getting sprint tasks taken care of). Despite prior issues with other management chains, I know that my current management chain advocates for me. With that in mind, I need to be more clear as to what I am working on and the direction I have in mind for the team and myself so that we may work together better.

Manager Summary:

As I mentioned earlier in the Strengths section Jon can perform at a high level when he's committed and believes in the end goal related to a task or project. When committed he demonstrates many of the SDE/leadership principles he calls out in the Strengths section.

Jon's shown less of these principles in areas where he questions the value or approach. As such I would agree the Disagree and Commit principle is an area for improvement. Jon struggled in the early and mid parts of the year with focus. During some of our sprints he struggled to stay on top of his assigned tasks, instead spending time on projects (e.g. Bundles) that he found more interesting and believed were critical to reaching his personal goal (promotion to SDE II). Less interesting sprint tasks could take longer to complete and that affected the team's overall productivity.

Some relevant peer feedback:

"Jon looks for guidance and support (which is a positive) however, in the absence of this support, he can struggle to proceed in an effective manner. Jon will be more effective when he is able to clearly communicate where he is having difficulty and the things that he needs to proceed."

"Jon can be a very hard worker, but he has difficulty in keeping his good work ethic when he needs to do a task or participate in a project that he is not excited about. He has a tendency to stray away

from the less "glamorous" tasks, and if he does need to do them, he sometimes works more slowly or gets preoccupied doing something else."

He also occasionally took on too many tasks (some sprint related, some not) and overloaded himself relative to the time he had to complete the work. He made strides here later in the year and into 2011, after I encouraged him to be more judicious about the number of tasks he takes on and the estimates he provides for time required to complete them. This was also a specific point of emphasis in the early 2011 performance improvement plan.

Similarly on occasion Jon displayed anger and frustration with immediate team members. For example during the early design phases of the distilled buybox project (during Q4 2010) Jon responded angrily to teammates when he felt his views weren't being heard. He directed blame at his team members and his outburst made his teammates uncomfortable.

Some relevant peer feedback:

"During a team meeting discussing our buy box redesign project, Jon expressed strong feelings with an angry tone that he did not believe our project was being organized or managed properly, along with strong distaste for the project, in general. While it is important to convey one's opinions, he had not communicated his thoughts sufficiently before this time, and the way in which he spoke placed blame only on others, instead of himself, even though he had been an active member in the team and in the project. His reaction created a tension in our team that was unnecessary, and with better communication, the issue probably could have been avoided."

"When Jon is upset or frustrating he expresses it very verbally and physically. I think it would be helpful for both him and the rest of the team if he finds ways to express this in a more productive manner. When he gets upset it doesn't help team morale or productivity. I totally understand the reasons why he is frustrated but if he can find a way to channel that energy in more positive ways I think everyone will be better off for it."

As noted Jon needs to consistently channel his energy and emotions in a positive way. After the outburst over the distilled buybox issues Jon admitted he handled it poorly. But a certain level of damage had already been done. And that behavior wasn't acceptable, which he also admitted.

Jon also displayed some frustrations via Remedy ticket correspondence on some occasions; an example is <https://tt.amazon.com/0009049155>. His comments questioned the severity of the ticket and noted how the ticket randomized him and other SDE's on the team for much of a day. These types of comments offer little value to solving the actual issue and can instead convey personal frustration directly to the ticket requestor. We then spoke about keeping ticket correspondence fact-based and devoid of emotional, potentially inflammatory comments. This was also a point of emphasis in the performance improvement plan.

In late February I put Jon on performance improvement plan. The areas requiring improvement were a) always channelling his emotions in positive way (e.g. refraining from displays of anger/frustration with the team environment) and showing consistent focus on assigned project/sprint work. During the plan Jon showed marked improvement -- he limited time spent on non-sprint work (e.g. the Bundles project) and exhibited constructive, positive written and verbal communication with internal/external team members and in written correspondence. His productivity increased dramatically. And he also said his attitude towards work improved as well. He successfully completed the performance improvement plan in late March.

As far as Earning the Trust of Others, his recent performance has led to improved communication with his teammates and a noticeable change with respect to his teammates expectations around Jon's ability to deliver as promised. Provided he keeps up the strong commitment and focus he's been showing this situation will only improve. His productivity continues to increase and as such he's finding more bandwidth to take on operational tasks and create tools (e.g. the Perl debugger

framework) that benefit the team. And he's gained the respect of sister teams like RCX QA.

Some relevant peer feedback:

"Jon has worked really closely with BX QA (and even Suchi from CatExp QA), listening to their concerns and helping them out with his domain knowledge as well as dev skills. He also demonstrated trust and respect to the QA engineers, and put in efforts to make the team bond better. As a result almost everyone in my team look up to him first when they need help from bx-dev-team."

Jon's clearly stated his current career goal: reaching SDE II. Jon has the tools to do so; for him the key is sustaining the recent focus, productivity and commitment to the team that he's shown in recent months.

Ratings

Performance Rating: Achieves

Leadership Principles Rating: Development Needed